The Nuclear Option

Until this period, limited resources had also played a role in curbing the Indian government's desire to exercise its nuclear option. This was also one of the reasons many in the US had not wanted India to acquire an independent nuclear weapons capability. When a Chinese nuclear test had seemed imminent in fall 1964, in order to deter India from going nuclear and investing heavily in conventional arms, Bowles had proposed to Indian officials that they seek an American nuclear umbrella.[196]

After China had conducted a nuclear test on October 16, 1964, Indian ambassador B. K. Nehru had noted the immense pressure on the Indian government to undertake a nuclear test because of the relative decline in India's power, as well as the "psychological advantage" China had attained. He had added, however, that the government had decided not to pursue a program, but warned that eventually it might not be able to resist the pressure.[197]

The US had wanted to discourage an Indian program on economic and security grounds. Officials debated what it might take to keep India from nuclearizing. An intelligence estimate had laid out three key factors that would likely play into any Indian decision to go for the bomb: (1) cost, (2) developments in the Chinese program and its impact on Chinese behavior, and (3) "the importance the Indians attach to assurances from the US and other nuclear powers."[198]

The US had taken some steps to alleviate immediate Indian anxieties and prevent a rush toward a nuclear weapons program. One concern had been the rise in China's status as a result of the test. Homi Bhabha, head of the Indian department of atomic energy, had sought American help to highlight other Indian achievements in science and technology.[199] And Washington had been willing to consider steps to address India's "prestige problem."[200] Furthermore, to give India a realistic estimate of the nuclear threat, the US had shared information with India on the Chinese program.[201] Finally, the US ambassador had made clear to the Indian atomic energy chief that he had underestimated the costs of—and perhaps even the time required for—producing an Indian bomb by at least two-thirds. Bowles had hoped that this would contribute to the Indian leadership's own concerns about costs that had been a deterrent in the past.[202]